

I. *It Was All Very Strange*

As I left the car, the air was cold and fresh, though disorienting. The sky was an odd shade of grey, a shade that was blue-tinged if you really squinted at it, but otherwise swept a monochrome light across the landscape. I walked into the rabbi's study with Warren on my arm.

It was a sorry excuse for a wedding. Of course I was happy to be getting married to the man I loved, but there were no fancy preparations aside from the ribbons draped across the walls, there were hardly any guests, and my father did not come to walk me down the aisle. There were the two of us—me and Warren—and then his sisters, their husbands, their kids, and my brother Michael. The room, though somewhat full, felt empty. My parents were not there.

That emptiness had engulfed me and Warren since we met. We met at an NYU Medical Mixer. I went there looking for a doctor, and so had he. We found each other instead—him, who was bouncing between jobs, and me, on track to become a teacher. At first, he wanted to dance with my friend, but I told her he was “the one,” and she understood. After that, we talked a whole lot. And he made me laugh a whole lot. But really, all that came of it was a quiet darkness. The sort of silence that buzzed and floated from room to room, the barely audible whispers between parents. Talk of money we couldn't know about, work we didn't care about, disapproval we felt but didn't talk about, and rest. And their lives, which I never asked about. I regret that to this day.

Warren was a part of that disapproval. He wasn't the right *kind* of Jewish. He wasn't the right *kind* of man. He wasn't “tall, dark, and handsome,” like my mother would have liked, and he wasn't wealthy either. But he was kind and gentle, so I loved him no matter what they said. My father loved my mother (or at least feared her) so he would not go against her. For that reason, they did not come to our wedding.

As the ceremony started, the rabbi's words, though loud and quick, slowly faded to the back of my mind. The guests sat in rows of wooden chairs, and my eyes bore into them until they meshed into an amalgamation of dull browns and fuzzy lines. It was meant to be a happy day, but I wasn't sure what I felt. Mostly hungry. We were supposed to go get Chinese food after— or at least, I think it was Chinese food— and that's all I could think of. My thoughts began to wander. Where had I lost the fairytale dream of my wedding day?

It was all very strange. My father was not there to walk me down the aisle, nor was my mother there to fix my hair or give a speech. Warren did not propose, nor did I. We did send out engagement announcements, purple ones. Still, there was no man bent down on his knee, or sobbing, a big, glitzy diamond ring, or any kind of jubilation. We didn't even set it up. We had been going together for two years, and his sister was a “busybody,” as women like her were often called, and she set the whole thing up.

We drove from Queens into New Jersey to a rabbi's study, which was situated near the synagogue but not entirely inside it. That's where the wedding was. To be married in the study instead of the synagogue itself was absurdly fitting.

I was Jewish, but not *really*. My family's concept of religion was blurry. I hadn't had a bat mitzvah, and my father was an atheist as far as religion was concerned. We would sometimes go to my grandmother's (mother's mother) apartment in Borough Park, Brooklyn, for the high holy days. She lived in a small place with three rooms and a bathroom. There was a big mirror above the couch, and my cousins and I would play in the bedroom and be told to quiet down. But then she died, and religion died with her.

With that, I was shaken from my stupor back into the study to focus on our wedding. We held hands as our wedding ceremony continued. The space in between them was warm and

grounding. Warren sensed my anxiety surrounding the whole thing, and brushed my hand with his fingers. He was there, and this was real. Our marriage was real. As the words “You may now kiss the bride” rang out into the air, hope escaped with them. We kissed, broke the glass, and sealed the future that once was a glimmer in the corner of our eyes, a small light in our peripheral. Of course I had grander dreams for the day, but the finality of being together with him was all that eventually mattered.

We left the wedding soon after, exchanging long, celebratory hugs with our family.

“Here’s some money for you and Warren to get on your feet,” Warren’s sister said as she slipped \$250 into my hands.

“Thank you,” I replied.

I smiled to myself, grateful that while my parents were not there, Warren’s family welcomed me with open arms.

The party rose to make our long-awaited way to the restaurant. People took their coats from the backs of their chairs and noisily thanked the rabbi for the ceremony. Exclamations like “Whose car are we taking?” and “Where are we eating?” sprang from the small crowd as we poured out through the door. The commotion seemed to bubble from the bottled-up silence we just sat in for a couple hours, saturating the air with laughter and conversation.

The wedding was not the way I’d dreamed it would be, but it was the day that spurred the rest of our lives.

Outside, there was still a slight chill, but the sky had cleared. The few clouds remaining were gold-flaked in the setting sun.

II. Mom

We got married in Battery Park. It was a hot June day, the first one of the month, and the bends of my mother's arm and mine melted together in the heat. Her skin was soft and lightly folded by time, while mine was still new and sticky in the damp June air. We both had freckles spattered up and down our arms, which creased into each other as we walked. I never really thought I looked like my mom. I had my father's eyes and mouth. The only thing I got from her was her curly hair, which was a heap of work, and I straightened it for the ceremony. But, as I walked down the aisle with her arm in mine, I noticed how similar we really were, down to our skin.

I had always been scared of age. The certainty of it. And it became startlingly near when we reached the altar. Here, I was going to set my life in the hands of a man I had known for a little more than four years, and I was to spend the rest of my life with him. I was to lay by his side until our hands molded to the shape of our interlocked fingers. I was to grow with him until I, too, lent my children my curly hair. Until I, too, set my arm beside my daughter's and noticed how similar we really were. Until I, too, aged into my mother's skin.

Then, unlike my mother at her wedding, all my anxieties quickly dissolved as she left me to face Lee, my hands clasped in his. I wanted to grow old with him. It was right.

I almost turned down my mother when she suggested walking me down the aisle. It was the antithesis to my lifelong dream of what my wedding would be: traditional. The whole thing was meant to be traditional. We did it by the book. Our vows were careful, our venue was fitting, and our roles in the wedding were set. We walked down the aisle to Pachelbel's Canon. We didn't take chances. But it was a compromise. She wouldn't replace my dad—he'd walk with me, too—but she wanted to be there for me in the way her parents were not at her wedding.

It was hot. We would soon have to move inside because of how warm it became. On each side of the aisle were about 30 white chairs. Two of these chairs were for my maternal grandparents. My grandfather seemed the happiest I had ever seen him. He was always a happy man, but he didn't smile much. Today, he beamed.

At the end of the aisle, near the officiant, was a wedding arch decorated with green leaves and more flowers to match those flung lazily about the carpet. To the left was the band (mostly composed of strings, so I guess it was more of an orchestra.) Indoors, there were chairs and tables set up for food after the ceremony, and a tiered, white cake with a yellow fondant bow on top. The aisle was covered by a long, white carpet, embellished with orange and yellow flowers scattered on either side.

I was in a strapless gown, so the little breeze that there was could at least brush my shoulders. He was in a tuxedo, and sweat kept running down the side of his face as he read his vows. He kept ducking further under the shade from the wedding arch, but the heat was all-encompassing and had already taken residence through the arms of his suit.

The sun beat down on the carpet, reflecting into our eyes. The glow bathed everything in an ethereal light, but despite its beauty, it felt suffocatingly warm. Lee began his vows.

"I promise to always choose you..."

A small bead of sweat embedded itself in his forehead.

"To love you..."

It shook loose as he moved his head, trailing down his nose.

"In sickness and in health..."

It dangled at the end of his nose, held there only by the humidity that coated his skin. I considered reaching out... just to wipe it... but no. It was silly to do that. It was my wedding day! I couldn't just...

At last, it dropped, and I laughed softly. It was such a ridiculous thing to fixate on in a moment as important as exchanging vows, which was now over. The officiant read through the few remaining pieces of the ceremony before stopping at the moment the entire wedding had led to.

"You may kiss the bride," the officiant declared.

We kissed, and time was suspended. Our fingers intertwined. The future was real, and it was here on a hot, muggy, June afternoon. The future wrinkled skin and it birthed mothers. It freckled flesh and bore dents into fingers. It drew lines across faces and it promised. It promised age, and with age, life.

The magic subsided and the moment regained its truth. We felt the weather once again. Sweat was still pouring down Lee's face, and a couple guests had to go buy dry "I Love NY" T-Shirts to change into. It was unbearably warm, so the party moved inside to the restaurant next door.

"It's really hot today, right?" Lee chuckled.

"Yes, oh my God! You were *drenched*," I responded playfully.

"I know!"

"It was literally taking, like, everything in me not to wipe it off your face."

They had just turned the air conditioning on, but they hadn't expected such a warm day, and it was too late. The sun already soaked into the white-walled rooms of the restaurant.

Through the windows, the Statue of Liberty stood tall in the Hudson River. The Statue's torch pierced the sky, marrying its gold to the blue.

The sky was clear and bright, and the few clouds that remained were silver-lined in the midday sun.